

Exploring Identity Through Storytelling

A transdisciplinary video unit for Grade 5 students in Uzbekistan. Every lesson teaches language, math, science, and social-emotional skills together, aligned to Uzbekistan's national curriculum and U.S. standards at the same time.

8 topics

24 sessions

3 languages on screen: English, Russian, Uzbek

3 frameworks: UZ national, Common Core & NGSS, CASEL

How every topic runs

A

Video lesson: introduce the big idea, vocabulary, and the math connection.

B

Video lesson: deepen it through culture, writing, and practice.

C · Live

Live session: discuss, share work, and reflect together.

Unit sequence: one theme, three subjects every week

Topic	Language	Math	Science & social studies
1 Culture and Identity	Figurative language; quoting from texts	Algebraic expressions	Understanding personal identity
2 Storytelling and Poetry	Figurative language and poetry	Writing and evaluating expressions	Cultural stories and identity
3 Understanding Diversity	Reading comprehension and discussion	Equivalent expressions	Recognizing and valuing diversity
4 Literature and Probability	Reading nonfiction; interpreting visuals	Probability	Probability in real-world contexts
5 Research and Presentation Skills	Note-taking and citing sources	Data analysis	Research methods and tools
6 Identity in Media	Media analysis and discussion	Media statistics	Representation in society
7 Community and Service	Reading about service projects	Planning and budgeting	Civic responsibility
8 Health and Well-being	Informational reading and note-taking	Data collection and display	The human body and health habits

Every topic also builds a CASEL social-emotional competency, and every lesson is mapped to both Uzbekistan's national curriculum and U.S. standards (see Lessons 1A and 1B).

Lesson 1A: Exploring Our Identity and Personal Characteristics

Topic 1 Culture and Identity

Format Video lesson, about 25 minutes

Hook Building an identity puzzle

Standards, side by side

Subject	U.S. standards (Common Core, NGSS, C3) and CASEL	Uzbekistan national curriculum
Social-emotional Identity and personal characteristics	CASEL Self-awareness	Describe aspects of individual and group identity within family and culture. UZ.LIT.5.3 Use adjectives to describe personal traits, orally and in writing.
Language arts Speaking and listening	SL.5.1 Engage effectively in collaborative discussions.	UZ.LIT.5.9 Engage in collaborative discussions and express ideas clearly.
Math Order of operations; solving equations	5.OA.1 Use parentheses, brackets, or braces in numerical expressions. 5.OA.2 Write and interpret simple expressions.	UZ.5.2 Evaluate and simplify expressions using correct operation order. UZ.5.3 Evaluate multi-step expressions; write and solve expressions.
Science Understanding personal identity	3-5-ETS1-1 Define a simple design problem reflecting a need or a want.	Describe aspects of individual and group identity within family and culture.

Lesson flow

- 1 Identity puzzle hook on an interactive whiteboard
- 2 Define "identity" in English, Russian, and Uzbek
- 3 Personal-characteristics vocabulary with model sentences
- 4 Multiple intelligences: where do your strengths lie?
- 5 Reflection on beliefs, values, and experiences
- 6 Math: expressions built from character traits
- 7 Add pieces to the class identity puzzle

Key vocabulary

identity characteristics unique
expression equation solve discuss
share

Student worksheet

- Choose 3–5 character traits from a word bank
- Give each a number value (its letter's place in the alphabet)
- Build equations from those traits and solve them
- Reflect on how the traits relate to your identity

Design choice: the math isn't a separate segment. Students turn the words that describe them into numbers, so practicing the order of operations becomes another way of exploring who they are.

Lesson 1B: Culture and Identity

Topic 1 Culture and Identity

Format Video lesson

Builds on Lesson 1A's identity puzzle

Standards, side by side

Subject	U.S. standards (Common Core, NGSS, C3) and CASEL	Uzbekistan national curriculum
Social-emotional Culture and cultural identity	CASEL Social awareness	Describe aspects of group identity and cultural practices. UZ.LIT.5.5 Discuss and reflect on personal and cultural identity.
Language arts Writing a descriptive paragraph	W.5.2 Write informative/explanatory texts with clear ideas.	UZ.LIT.5.8 Write descriptive texts using specific vocabulary.
Math Order of operations; solving equations	5.OA.1 Use parentheses, brackets, or braces. 5.OA.2 Write and interpret simple expressions.	UZ.5.2 Correct operation order. UZ.5.3 Write and solve multi-step expressions.
Science Understanding cultural influence	3-5-ETS1-1 Define a design problem reflecting cultural needs.	Relate cultural practices to individual identity.
Social studies Cultural traditions and heritage	D2.His.2.3-5 Compare life across cultures.	UZ.SS.5.2 Explain cultural customs and celebrations.

Lesson overview

Students revisit identity and deepen it through culture. The teacher guides a collage or drawing of cultural elements, a descriptive paragraph, and math practice using the order of operations.

Key vocabulary

culture

tradition

symbol

celebration

identity

represent

describe

reflect

Student worksheet

- List 3 cultural elements from your collage
- Assign a value to each element
- Write an equation using those values
- Solve it using the order of operations
- Explain each element's cultural meaning, using sentence stems

Materials

- Colored paper, magazines or printed images
- Scissors, glue, notebooks, pencils
- Sentence stem templates and math problem cards

How 1B builds on 1A: students move from personal traits to the culture around them, using the same equation routine, so the math stays familiar while the writing and thinking get deeper.